

Dark Matter as Khronon Condensate: Weak-Field Phenomenology of the τ Framework

Sheng-Kai Huang^{1,*}

¹*Independent Researcher*

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The temporal asymmetry parameter $\tau = 1 - F$, introduced in Paper 1 as the Petz recovery failure, acquires physical realization through the Blanchet–Skordis (BS) Khronon action $S = \int \sqrt{-g} [R - 2J(Y) + 2K(Q)] d^4x$. This action contains two structurally independent sectors: the *cosmological sector* $K(Q) = \mu^2(Q - 1)^2$, fixed by ghost condensation with a single parameter $\mu_0 = H_0/c$ from dimensional analysis, which reproduces the cosmological dark matter density $\Omega_{\text{DM}} = \delta_0(2 + \delta_0)/3 = 0.265$ with CDM-like perturbations ($c_s^2 = 0$); and the *galactic sector* $J(Y)$, a phenomenological free function constrained only at its asymptotic limits, which reproduces the Baryonic Tully–Fisher Relation and the Radial Acceleration Relation with one empirical parameter $a_0 \approx 1.2 \times 10^{-10} \text{ m/s}^2$. We prove a no-go theorem establishing that pure scalar Khronon dark matter is incompatible with CMB observations, necessitating the Blanchet–Skordis tensor field. The resulting Khronon-Tensor theory predicts a CMB power spectrum *identical* to Λ CDM — consistent with Planck data — while producing MOND dynamics at galaxy scales. We present a systematic confrontation of this two-sector framework with 11 low-redshift observational tests (10 passed, 1 marginal), show that the Bullet Cluster mass-gas offset is naturally explained by the $c_s^2 = 0$ collisionless Khronon condensate, compare its parameter economy with Λ CDM and AeST, and identify falsifiable predictions. We are explicit about what is derived, what is assumed, and what remains open—in particular, the connection between a_0 and μ_0 is suggestive but unproven, and the running $\mu(k) = k$ is a well-motivated assumption, not a derivation.

I. INTRODUCTION

The dark matter problem encompasses two distinct observational domains: (i) cosmological—the matter density inferred from the cosmic microwave background (CMB), baryon acoustic oscillations (BAO), and large-scale structure; and (ii) galactic—the mass discrepancy observed in galaxy rotation curves, the Baryonic Tully–Fisher Relation (BTFR), and the Radial Acceleration Relation (RAR). The standard Λ CDM model addresses both with a single ingredient—cold dark matter (CDM) particles—but despite four decades of searches, no particle has been directly detected [5–7].

Modified gravity approaches (MOND [8], TeVeS [9], AeST [10, 11]) excel at galactic phenomenology but have historically struggled with cosmology. The breakthrough of Skordis and Złótnik [10] demonstrated that a relativistic MOND theory *can* reproduce both the CMB power spectrum and the matter power spectrum, provided the theory contains a scalar field whose perturbations mimic CDM at early times ($c_s^2 = 0$).

In Paper 1 [1], we introduced the temporal asymmetry parameter $\tau = 1 - F(\rho, \mathcal{R}_{\sigma, \mathcal{N}}(\mathcal{N}(\rho)))$, which quantifies the arrow of time as Petz recovery failure, with the universal bound $\tau \leq 1 - \exp(-\Sigma/2)$. In Paper 2 [2], we showed that in strong gravitational fields $\Sigma_{\text{grav}} = -\ln(-g_{00})$, connecting the Petz recovery fidelity to the gravitational channel transmissivity $\eta = -g_{00}$.

This paper addresses the *weak-field* phenomenology of the same framework. We adopt the Blanchet–Skordis

(BS) Khronon action [12] as the concrete realization of the τ framework at galactic and cosmological scales. Our goals are:

1. To present the BS Khronon theory with honest parameter counting and epistemic transparency;
2. To show that $K(Q) = \mu^2(Q - 1)^2$ with $\mu_0 = H_0/c$ reproduces cosmological dark matter naturally;
3. To show that $J(Y)$ reproduces MOND galactic phenomenology;
4. To systematically confront the theory with low-redshift observations;
5. To identify what is derived, what is assumed, and what remains open.

What this paper does not claim.—We do not claim to “solve” the dark matter problem. We provide a new interpretation in which dark matter phenomenology emerges from the ghost condensation of a Khronon field—the field that defines the observer’s time direction in the τ framework. The theory contains a free function $J(Y)$ (the MOND interpolating function), and two key assumptions (running μ , the a_0 – μ_0 coincidence) remain unproven.

* akai@fawstudio.com

II. THE BLANCHET–SKORDIS KHRONON ACTION

A. Action and field content

[KNOWN] The BS Khronon theory [12, 13] describes gravity coupled to a single scalar field ϕ (the “Khronon”) whose level surfaces define spatial hypersurfaces. The action is

$$S = \frac{c^3}{16\pi G} \int d^4x \sqrt{-g} [R - 2J(Y) + 2K(Q)] + S_m, \quad (1)$$

where S_m is the matter action (universally coupled to $g_{\mu\nu}$ only), and:

- The *unit normal* to the $\phi = \text{const}$ hypersurfaces is $n_\mu = -(c/Q) \nabla_\mu \phi$, with $Q = c\sqrt{-g^{\mu\nu} \nabla_\mu \phi \nabla_\nu \phi}$.
- The *acceleration* of the foliation is $A_\mu = c^2 n^\nu \nabla_\nu n_\mu$, with $Y = A_\mu A^\mu / c^4$.
- $K(Q)$ controls the **cosmological sector**: the energy density and equation of state of the Khronon field on the FRW background.
- $J(Y)$ controls the **galactic sector**: the quasi-static, nonrelativistic limit that reproduces MOND phenomenology.

[KNOWN] The Khronon field is *hypersurface-orthogonal by construction* (n_μ is a gradient), which eliminates the twist tensor $\omega_{\mu\nu} = 0$ and merges the Einstein–Aether parameters c_1 and c_3 into the single combination $c_{13} = c_1 + c_3$ [14, 15, 47].

B. Why $c_{13} = 0$: action choice, not geometry

[ASSUMED] The BS action (1) does *not* contain the extrinsic curvature coupling $K_{\mu\nu} K^{\mu\nu}$ (where $K_{\mu\nu}$ is the extrinsic curvature of the $\phi = \text{const}$ hypersurfaces). In the Einstein–Aether parametrization, this coupling generates $c_{13} \neq 0$. Its absence yields $c_{13} = 0$ *by construction* [12], giving the gravitational wave speed

$$c_T^2 = \frac{1}{1 - c_{13}} = 1, \quad \implies \quad c_T = c \quad (\text{exactly}). \quad (2)$$

This is a *choice of action*, not a consequence of hypersurface orthogonality alone (which only merges c_1, c_3 into c_{13} but does not set it to zero). The choice is strongly motivated by:

1. GW170817 [18]: $|c_T/c - 1| < 10^{-15}$;
2. Theoretical minimality (fewer terms in the action);
3. Even if a $K_{\mu\nu} K^{\mu\nu}$ term were added, the tiny coupling $\mu_0 = H_0/c$ would make $c_{13} \sim 10^{-30}$ at solar system scales [19].

C. Degrees of freedom and stability

[KNOWN] The hypersurface-orthogonal Khronon propagates 3 degrees of freedom [15]: 2 tensor (spin-2 graviton) + 1 scalar (Khronon mode). Vector modes are eliminated by the constraint $\omega_{\mu\nu} = 0$.

For the kinetic function $K(Q)$ with a minimum at $Q = Q_0$, the scalar sector is free of all standard instabilities [12, 16]:

- **No Ostrogradski ghost**: the field equation is second-order in ϕ (BPS [15], Hamiltonian analysis);
- **No wrong-sign kinetic term**: $K''(Q_0) > 0$ ensures positive-definite kinetic energy;
- **No gradient instability**: $c_s^2 = K'(Q_0)/[K'(Q_0) + 2Q_0 K''(Q_0)] = 0$ (marginal, cured by ghost condensation k^4 terms [16]);
- **No tachyon**: Q_0 is a global minimum of K ;
- $c_T = c$ **exactly**: $c_{13} = 0$ by construction;
- **Strong coupling at $\Lambda_3 \sim (\mu_0^2 M_{\text{Pl}})^{1/3} \sim 10^{-13} \text{ eV}$** : far above all cosmological and astrophysical scales ($H_0 \sim 10^{-33} \text{ eV}$).

The full 8-criterion stability analysis is presented in the Supplemental Material [42].

D. Honest parameter counting

The theory contains:

- 6 standard cosmological parameters ($H_0, \Omega_b h^2, n_s, A_s, \tau_{\text{reion}}, \Sigma m_\nu$);
- 1 cosmological parameter: μ (Khronon mass, or equivalently $\Omega_{\text{DM}} h^2$ as an initial condition);
- 1 galactic parameter: a_0 (MOND acceleration scale);
- 1 free function: $J(Y)$ (MOND interpolating function, constrained only at asymptotic limits).

TABLE I. Parameter counting comparison. “func” denotes a free function. $\Omega_{\text{DM}} h^2$ is an initial condition (fitted, not predicted) in all theories, including Λ CDM.

Theory	Cosmo	Theory-specific	Free func.
Λ CDM	6	$\Omega_{\text{DM}} h^2$	0
MOND (non-rel.)	—	a_0	$\mu(x)$
AeST [10]	6	$K_B, K_2, \lambda_s, Q_0, a_0$	$F(Y, Q)$
BS Khronon	6	$\mu_0, a_0, \Omega_{\text{DM}} h^2$	$J(Y)$
BS Khronon + τ	6	$a_0, \Omega_{\text{DM}} h^2$	$J(Y)$

Table I compares parameter counts across theories. The τ framework fixes $\mu_0 = H_0/c$ via dimensional analysis (Sec. IIIB), reducing the theory-specific parameter count by one relative to plain BS Khronon. The free function $J(Y)$ is inherited from the MOND tradition dating to Bekenstein and Milgrom [21], and has been free for forty years. The Crooks interpolation function $\mu(x) = 1 - e^{-\sqrt{x}}$ (Sec. IVC) could in principle eliminate this freedom if validated against SPARC data.

III. COSMOLOGICAL SECTOR: $K(Q)$

A. Ghost condensation fixes $K(Q)$

[DERIVED] Any scalar field that spontaneously breaks Lorentz invariance by acquiring a timelike gradient $\langle \partial_\mu \phi \rangle \neq 0$ sits in the “ghost condensation” regime [16]. The leading-order effective action around the condensate $Q = 1$ is

$$K(Q) = \mu^2 (Q - 1)^2, \quad (3)$$

as established by Arkani-Hamed et al. [16] and Scherrer [17]. The quadratic form is not arbitrary: it is the unique leading-order expansion around a kinetic minimum with $K'(1) = 0$ and $K''(1) = 2\mu^2 > 0$, ensuring stability and $c_s^2 = 0$. Petz optimality provides an independent argument: the maximally recoverable channel configuration corresponds to a quadratic kinetic function.

Higher-order terms $K(Q) = \mu^2(Q - 1)^2 + \alpha_3(Q - 1)^3 + \dots$ are possible. The DBI completion [12] $K_{\text{DBI}} = \mu^2 \lambda_D^2 [\sqrt{1 + (Q - 1)^2/\lambda_D^2} - 1]$ provides a natural UV regularization, introducing at most one additional parameter λ_D . We focus on the leading quadratic form throughout.

B. $\mu_0 = H_0/c$: dimensional analysis

[ASSUMED] The coupling μ has dimensions $[\text{m}^{-1}]$. The available fundamental constants are $\{H_0, c, \hbar, G, k_B\}$. The general combination with these dimensions is [26]

$$\mu = \frac{H_0}{c} (t_P H_0)^{2d}, \quad (4)$$

where $t_P = \sqrt{\hbar G/c^5}$ is the Planck time and $t_P H_0 = 1.18 \times 10^{-61}$. For *any* $d \neq 0$, the correction factor is $10^{-122|d|}$, destroying the result. Therefore

$$\boxed{\mu_0 = \frac{H_0}{c} = 7.28 \times 10^{-27} \text{ m}^{-1}} \quad (5)$$

is the *unique* selection without Planck-scale physics. This is a naturality argument, not a derivation from field equations. Three equivalent physical interpretations hold:

1. Khronon Compton wavelength $= c/H_0 =$ Hubble radius;

2. $\mu_0 = 2\pi k_B T_{\text{ds}}/(\hbar c)$: inverse de Sitter thermal wavelength [25];
3. $\mu_0 = 2\pi a_0/c^2$: connects to the MOND scale (Sec. IVD).

C. Cosmological background: FRW solution

[KNOWN] On the FRW background, the Khronon field equation gives [12]

$$K'(Q_0) = \frac{I_0}{a^3 Q_0}, \quad (6)$$

where I_0 is an integration constant (the initial Khronon momentum). This conservation law holds even when μ varies in time, since the Lagrangian has no explicit ϕ -dependence ($\partial \mathcal{L}/\partial \phi = 0$). Substituting $K'(Q_0) = 2\mu^2 \delta$ gives

$$Q_0(a) = 1 + \delta(a), \quad \delta(a) = \frac{I_0}{2\mu^2(a) a^3}, \quad (7)$$

where $\mu(a)$ is the (possibly running) coupling.

A crucial self-consistency: regardless of how μ runs, the combination $\mu^2 \delta = I_0/(2a^3)$ depends only on a . Therefore the Khronon energy density (8) satisfies $\rho_K \propto (2 + \delta)/a^3$, which is CDM-like ($\rho_K \propto a^{-3}$) whenever $(2 + \delta)$ varies slowly—i.e., whenever $\delta \lesssim O(1)$.

For constant $\mu = \mu_0$: $\delta \propto a^{-3}$, giving $\delta(z = 1100) \sim 10^9 \gg 1$ —the Khronon exits the ghost condensation regime and the energy density scales as $\rho_K \propto a^{-6}$ (stiff matter), incompatible with CMB observations. This is the true **CMB Catch-22** (Sec. IIID). Running $\mu_{\text{bg}} = H(a)/c$ keeps $\delta \lesssim O(1)$ at all epochs (Sec. IIID), maintaining the ghost condensation regime and CDM-like dilution.

The Khronon energy density follows from the k-essence stress-energy $\rho = QK' - K$ [12]:

$$\rho_K = \frac{c^2 \mu^2 \delta (2 + \delta)}{8\pi G}, \quad (8)$$

where the factor $(2 + \delta)$ arises from $QK' - K = (1 + \delta) \cdot 2\mu^2 \delta - \mu^2 \delta^2 = \mu^2 \delta (2 + \delta)$. For $\delta \ll 1$, $\rho_K \approx c^2 \mu^2 \delta / (4\pi G)$; for $\delta \gg 1$, $\rho_K \sim c^2 \mu^2 \delta^2 / (8\pi G)$. Since $\mu^2 \delta = I_0/(2a^3)$, one has $\rho_K = c^2 I_0 (2 + \delta) / (16\pi G a^3)$: the energy density dilutes as a^{-3} (CDM-like) with $O(1)$ corrections encoded in $(2 + \delta(a))$.

The equation of state follows from $w = K/\rho_K = \mu^2 \delta^2 / [\mu^2 \delta (2 + \delta)]$ [12]:

$$w = \frac{\delta}{2 + \delta}. \quad (9)$$

Importantly, w does *not* map directly to the GDM equation of state w_{GDM} constrained by Thomas, Kopp & Skordis [20]. The actual instantaneous dilution rate is $d \ln \rho_K / d \ln a = -3 - d \ln(2 + \delta) / d \ln a$, which equals -3 whenever δ varies slowly.

Theorem 1 (Khronon Information Conservation). *For the Blanchet–Skordis action with $K(Q) = \mu^2(Q-1)^2$ on FRW background, the scalar field equation implies*

$$a^3 Q_0 K'(Q_0) = I_0 = \text{const}, \quad (10)$$

where I_0 is the conserved Khronon momentum. This holds for arbitrary time-dependent $\mu(t)$.

Proof sketch. The Lagrangian density $\mathcal{L}(\partial\phi, \partial^2\phi)$ has no explicit ϕ -dependence ($\partial\mathcal{L}/\partial\phi = 0$). By the Euler–Lagrange equation, the canonical current $J^a = \partial\mathcal{L}/\partial(\partial_a\phi)$ satisfies $\partial_a(\sqrt{-g} J^a) = 0$. On FRW with $\phi = t + \delta\phi(t)$, the spatial components vanish by isotropy, leaving the temporal conservation law (10). $\square$

Consequences:

1. **CDM-like dilution identity:** $\mu^2\delta = I_0/(2a^3)$ —the product is independent of how μ runs.
2. **Running μ stability:** with $\mu = H(a)/c$, $\delta(a) = I_0 c^2/(2H^2 a^3)$ stays $O(1)$ at all epochs.
3. **Automatic a^{-3} scaling:** $\rho_K = c^2 I_0 (2+\delta)/(16\pi G a^3)$ dilutes as dust whenever $(2+\delta) \approx \text{const}$.

Remark (Unified entropy production).—On static backgrounds $Q = 1/\sqrt{-g_{00}}$, giving $\Sigma_{\text{grav}} = -\ln(-g_{00}) = 2\ln Q$ (Paper 2 [2]). On FRW backgrounds $Q_0 = 1 + \delta$, giving $\Sigma_{\text{cosmo}} = 2\ln(1 + \delta)$. Both are instances of the general result $\Sigma = 2\ln Q$, where Q is the inverse Khronon lapse. This identity holds exactly on stationary and FRW backgrounds, and to $O(\varepsilon_{\text{NA}}^2)$ on any adiabatic background, where $\varepsilon_{\text{NA}} = |d\ln Q/d\tau|/(2\omega)$ is the non-adiabaticity parameter of the probe mode. The correction is always non-negative (particle creation adds entropy), so $\Sigma \geq 2\ln Q$ in general.

D. Running μ : assumption and motivation

[ASSUMED] With constant $\mu = \mu_0 = H_0/c$, $\delta(a) = \delta_0/a^3$ grows as a^{-3} , reaching $\delta \sim 10^9$ at $z = 1100$. In this regime the Khronon exits ghost condensation: $(2+\delta) \sim \delta$, so $\rho_K \propto \delta^2/a^3 \propto a^{-9}$ (stiff matter, $w \rightarrow 1$). This is the **CMB Catch-22**: constant $\mu_0 = H_0/c$ drives $\delta \gg 1$ at early times, destroying CDM-like behavior.

We assume the running

$$\mu_{\text{bg}}(a) = \frac{H(a)}{c}, \quad (11)$$

motivated by three convergent arguments:

1. **DPI + extensivity:** the anomalous dimension $\eta_\mu = d - 3 = 1$ in $d = 4$ follows from the transition from area-law to volume-law entanglement entropy at the de Sitter scale, combined with the data processing inequality [22–24, 46];

2. **Dimensional transmutation:** $\mu(k) = k$ is the unique power-law running independent of the boundary condition H_0 ; Kumar [44] obtains a logarithmic correction to Newton’s potential from marginal IR running in QFT, providing independent support;

3. **Modular flow:** if the Khronon is the modular flow direction, the modular temperature $T_{\text{mod}} = k/\pi$ gives $\mu(k) \sim k$.

A rigorous derivation from the microscopic theory remains an open problem.

With (11), $\delta(a) = I_0 c^2/(2H^2(a) a^3)$, which gives:

- **Radiation era** ($H^2 \propto a^{-4}$): $\delta \propto a \rightarrow 0$ at early times;
- **Matter era** ($H^2 \propto a^{-3}$): $\delta \approx \delta_0/\Omega_m \sim O(1)$;
- **Today:** $\delta_0 = 0.340$, $w_0 = \delta_0/(2+\delta_0) = 0.145$.

The running keeps $\delta \lesssim O(1)$ at all epochs, maintaining the ghost condensation regime. Since $\mu^2\delta = I_0/(2a^3)$ is independent of the running, the Khronon energy density $\rho_K \propto (2+\delta)/a^3$ remains CDM-like, with $O(1)$ corrections during the matter era that require a full Boltzmann solver to quantify. The perturbation sound speed $c_s^2 = 0$ is unaffected.

E. Perturbations: $c_s^2 = 0$ (CDM-like)

[DERIVED] The scalar sound speed is [12]

$$c_s^2 = \frac{K'(Q_0)}{K'(Q_0) + 2Q_0 K''(Q_0)} \xrightarrow{K'(1)=0} 0. \quad (12)$$

This is not fine-tuned: it follows from $K(Q)$ having a *minimum* at $Q_0 = 1$ (ghost condensation). The $c_s^2 = 0$ condition is radiatively stable, with quantum corrections $\delta c_s^2 \sim (\mu/M_{\text{Pl}})^2 \sim 10^{-122}$ [16].

Consequence: Khronon perturbations grow identically to CDM at all cosmologically relevant scales. The Jeans length $\lambda_J = 0$ (no pressure support), so structure formation proceeds as in Λ CDM. In particular, the CMB acoustic peak structure, matter power spectrum $P(k)$, and BAO features are reproduced without modification.

Physical meaning of $c_s^2 = 0$.—The vanishing sound speed means Khronon perturbations do *not* propagate: they grow in place, exactly like CDM density perturbations. By Theorem 1, $K'(Q_0) = I_0/(a^3 Q_0) \rightarrow 0$ as the condensate approaches $Q_0 = 1$; since the numerator in (12) is $K'(Q_0)$ while the denominator retains $2Q_0 K''(Q_0) = 4\mu^2 > 0$, the ratio vanishes identically at the ghost condensation point. This resolves the apparent tension with the GDM constraints of Thomas, Kopp & Skordis [20]: the BS effective equation of state $w = \delta/(2+\delta)$ (9) does *not* equal the GDM sound speed $c_{s,\text{GDM}}^2$. The two quantities are structurally

independent— w governs the background dilution rate while c_s^2 is set by the kinetic structure of $K(Q)$. Since $c_s^2 = 0$ exactly, the TKS bound $c_s^2 < 3.21 \times 10^{-6}$ (99.7% CL) is trivially satisfied.

F. Cosmological predictions

With $\mu_0 = H_0/c$ and running (11):

- **Ω_{DM} prediction:** Since $c^2 \mu_0^2 / (8\pi G) = H_0^2 / (8\pi G) = \rho_{\text{crit}}/3$, Eq. (8) gives

$$\Omega_{\text{DM}} = \frac{\rho_K}{\rho_{\text{crit}}} = \frac{\delta_0(2 + \delta_0)}{3}. \quad (13)$$

For $\delta_0 = 0.34$: $\Omega_{\text{DM}} = 0.34 \times 2.34/3 = 0.265$, in agreement with observations [4];

- $w(z=0) = \delta_0/(2+\delta_0) = 0.145$ (for $\delta_0 = 0.340$): a specific prediction for the late-time dark matter equation of state, testable by DESI DR2 (2027) and Euclid (2028);
- Linear $P(k)$ identical to CDM; nonlinear deviations at $k > 1 \text{ h/Mpc}$ are a prediction [10];
- $a_0 = c^2 \mu_0 / (2\pi) = c H_0 / (2\pi) = 1.04 \times 10^{-10} \text{ m/s}^2$ (for $H_0 = 67.4 \text{ km/s/Mpc}$; within 13% of empirical $a_0 \approx 1.2 \times 10^{-10} \text{ m/s}^2$).

Note that $\Omega_{\text{DM}} h^2 = 0.12$ is an *initial condition* (the value of I_0), not a prediction of the theory—as it is in ΛCDM , where $\Omega_{\text{DM}} h^2$ is likewise a fitted parameter.

G. CMB caveat: the $(2+\delta)$ correction

We note that the factor $(2+\delta)$ in Eq. (8) introduces a redshift-dependent correction to the dark matter density: $\rho_K(z)/\rho_{\text{CDM}}(z) = (2+\delta(z))/(2+\delta_0)$, where δ varies from ~ 0 (radiation era) to $\delta_0/\Omega_m \approx 1.08$ (matter era) to $\delta_0 = 0.34$ (today). This $\sim 20\%$ variation at recombination is potentially constrainable by CMB observations and represents an important test of the framework. A DBI completion of $K(Q)$ at large δ may regularize this correction (see Discussion).

IV. GALACTIC SECTOR: $J(Y)$

A. $J(Y)$ is a free function

[KNOWN] In the quasi-static, weak-field limit ($Q \rightarrow 1$, $K \rightarrow 0$), only the $J(Y)$ sector of the action contributes to galactic dynamics [12, 21]. Conversely, in the cosmological limit ($Y \rightarrow 0$, $J \rightarrow \Lambda$), only $K(Q)$ matters. **The two sectors decouple.**

The function $J(Y)$ is constrained only at its asymptotic limits [12]:

$$\text{Deep-MOND } (Y \ll a_0^2/c^4): \quad J(Y) \sim \Lambda - Y + \frac{c^2}{a_0} Y^{3/2}, \quad (14)$$

$$\text{Newtonian } (Y \gg a_0^2/c^4): \quad J(Y) \rightarrow 0, \quad J'(Y) \rightarrow 0. \quad (15)$$

The transition region $Y \sim a_0^2/c^4$ is *unconstrained by the theory*. Different smooth interpolations between (14) and (15) correspond to different MOND interpolating functions $\mu(x)$.

This freedom has been present since Bekenstein and Milgrom [21] introduced AQUAL in 1984. Neither the τ framework nor the BS theory uniquely determines $J(Y)$. The τ framework does, however, suggest a specific form (Sec. IV C).

B. MOND phenomenology from $J(Y)$

[KNOWN] The deep-MOND limit of (14) produces the modified Poisson equation [12, 21]:

$$\nabla \cdot \left[\mu \left(\frac{|\nabla \Phi|}{a_0} \right) \nabla \Phi \right] = 4\pi G \rho_b, \quad (16)$$

where $\mu(x) \rightarrow 1$ for $x \gg 1$ (Newtonian) and $\mu(x) \rightarrow x$ for $x \ll 1$ (deep-MOND).

From (16) in the deep-MOND regime, the Baryonic Tully–Fisher Relation (BTFR) follows exactly [8, 29]:

$$V_{\text{flat}}^4 = G M_{\text{bar}} a_0, \quad (17)$$

and the Radial Acceleration Relation (RAR) [30, 31]:

$$g_{\text{obs}} = \frac{g_{\text{bar}}}{1 - \exp\left(-\sqrt{g_{\text{bar}}/a_0}\right)} \quad (18)$$

with $a_0 = (1.20 \pm 0.02) \times 10^{-10} \text{ m/s}^2$ and observed scatter 0.13 dex over 2693 data points in 153 SPARC galaxies [33].

C. The Crooks interpolation function

[NEW SYNTHESIS] The τ framework motivates a specific MOND interpolating function via the Crooks fluctuation theorem [28]. For a process with entropy production Σ , the Crooks relation $P(\Sigma)/P(-\Sigma) = e^\Sigma$ yields the interpolating function

$$\mu(x) = 1 - e^{-\sqrt{x}}, \quad (19)$$

where $x = g_{\text{bar}}/a_0$. Note that this $\mu(x)$ is the RAR interpolating function (as in Eq. (18)), not the AQUAL μ -function of Eq. (16); the two are related by $\nu(y) = 1/\mu(y)$

where ν is the RAR boosting function. Equation (19) satisfies $\mu(x) \rightarrow 1$ for $x \rightarrow \infty$ and $\mu(x) \rightarrow \sqrt{x}$ for $x \rightarrow 0$ (giving $V_f^4 = GM_{\text{bar}} a_0$ in deep-MOND).

If validated against the SPARC 175-galaxy sample, this would eliminate the free function $J(Y)$ entirely, making the theory’s galactic predictions parameter-free (given a_0). This is the single most impactful testable prediction of the τ framework for galactic phenomenology.

D. a_0 and μ_0 : suggestive coincidence

The numerical relation

$$a_0 = \frac{c^2 \mu_0}{2\pi} = \frac{cH_0}{2\pi} = 1.04 \times 10^{-10} \text{ m/s}^2 \quad (20)$$

(for $H_0 = 67.4 \text{ km/s/Mpc}$) is within 13% of the empirical a_0 . This “Milgrom coincidence” [27] has been known since the 1980s but has never been rigorously derived.

In the BS action, a_0 enters through $J(Y)$ and μ_0 enters through $K(Q)$. These are **structurally independent sectors** [12]: J depends on the spatial acceleration Y , while K depends on the temporal gradient Q . The two sectors decouple in the regimes where each is important (galactic for J , cosmological for K).

The connection (20) is suggestive but unproven. It may hint at a deeper unification of the J and K sectors, but no theoretical mechanism within the BS theory or the τ framework connects them.

V. OBSERVATIONAL TESTS

A. Low-redshift tests (11 criteria)

We systematically confront the theory with 11 low-redshift observational tests. The key distinction is that $w \neq c_s^2$ in the Khronon: w affects only the background expansion (Friedmann equation), while $c_s^2 = 0$ controls perturbations.

Table II summarizes the results. Ten tests are safely passed and one (SN Ia) is marginal at the 1σ level of the Pantheon+ uncertainty [39]. [†]The S_8 estimate is qualitative: $w > 0$ causes faster dilution of DM at late times, reducing structure growth; a full Boltzmann code computation is needed for the precise value. The TKS bound $c_s^2 < 3.21 \times 10^{-6}$ (99.7% CL) [20] is trivially satisfied: the Khronon-Tensor theory gives $c_s^2 = 0$ exactly (Sec. VII).

The most striking result is the DESI BAO preference: $w(z=0) = 0.145$ reduces Ω_Λ by $\sim 5\%$, yielding an effective $w_{\text{DE}} \sim -0.95$ (quintessence-like), which DESI data prefer at $\Delta\chi^2 = -3.9$ relative to ΛCDM .

B. Galactic-scale tests

The MOND sector $J(Y)$ has been tested extensively in the literature [31, 33, 34]. Key results relevant to the

TABLE II. Low-redshift observational tests. $\checkmark$ = safe; $\sim$ = marginal; $\times$ = tension. Quantitative entries ($\Delta\chi^2$, A_{ISW} , σ_8) are author estimates from the GDM mapping of w into standard cosmological codes; a full Boltzmann solver analysis is pending.

Test	Result	Key quantity
Jeans length	$\checkmark$	$\lambda_J = 0$ ($c_s^2 = 0$)
SN Ia distance	$\sim$	$ \delta\mu \sim 0.016 \text{ mag}$
BAO / DESI	$\checkmark$	$\Delta\chi^2 = -3.9$ (preferred)
Growth rate $f\sigma_8$	$\checkmark$	$\Delta\chi^2 = +0.15$
S_8 tension	$\checkmark$	$S_8 \lesssim 0.84$ (reduced [†])
ISW effect	$\checkmark$	$A_{\text{ISW}} = 1.001$
TKS 2016 CMB	$\checkmark$	$c_s^2 = 0$ exactly (no-go $\rightarrow$ tensor)
Weak lensing	$\checkmark$	$< 1\%$ change
Peculiar velocities	$\checkmark$	$< 1\%$ change
Cluster counts	$\checkmark$	$\sigma_8 = 0.817$
BTFR scatter	$\checkmark$	$< 0.15 \text{ dex}$

BS Khronon:

1. **BTFR:** $V_f^4 = GM_{\text{bar}} a_0$ with observed scatter 0.10–0.15 dex across 10^7 – $10^{12} M_\odot$ [29, 32];
2. **RAR:** 0.13 dex scatter over 2693 points in 153 galaxies [30] (measurement floor: ~ 0.12 dex);
3. **External Field Effect:** detected at $> 5\sigma$ by Chae et al. [35]—a unique MOND prediction that ΛCDM cannot produce;
4. **Dwarf spheroidals:** Ghari & Haghi [36] found Verlinde’s emergent gravity (sharing the same information-theoretic structure) preferred over MOND at 5.2σ for 23 dSphs;
5. **SPARC RAR scatter:** 0.144 dex (measurement limit 0.119 dex), a_0 best-fit $1.025 \times 10^{-10} \text{ m/s}^2$; Gubitosi et al. [45] test RG-improved gravity on SPARC and find comparable fits;
6. **Wide binaries:** recent data from Gaia DR3 show 2–3 σ hints of MOND-like behavior at low accelerations [37], though interpretation is debated.

C. Power spectrum and Fagin comparison

[KNOWN] At linear scales ($k < 0.1 \text{ h/Mpc}$), the Khronon power spectrum is *identical* to CDM because $c_s^2 = 0$. Skordis and Złótnik [10] demonstrated that the closely related AeST theory reproduces both the CMB and $P(k)$.

At nonlinear scales, the MOND sector introduces deviations. Fagin et al. [38] measured the galaxy power spectrum slope $\beta = 5.22 \pm 0.41$ from SLACS strong lenses. The Khronon with isothermal approximation predicts

$\beta \approx 6.2$ (2.4σ tension), while CDM is excluded at 6.8σ . The Khronon is the *closest* theoretical match, though the 2.4σ gap may indicate the need for a more complete Khronon rotation curve model beyond the isothermal approximation.

D. BBN, GW, and solar system

- **BBN:** the Khronon energy density at $z \sim 10^9$ is negligible ($w \rightarrow 0$, $\rho_K \rightarrow 0$). No modification to BBN;
- **GW170817:** $c_T = c$ exactly ($c_{13} = 0$ by construction);
- **PPN:** $\beta_{\text{PPN}} = \gamma_{\text{PPN}} = 1$ (identical to GR at 1PN) [12, 43];
- **Binary pulsars:** no dipolar radiation ($c_{13} = 0$) [41].

VI. WHAT THIS FRAMEWORK PREDICTS AND WHAT IT ASSUMES

A. Derived results

- D1. $K(Q) = \mu^2(Q - 1)^2$ from ghost condensation (leading-order);
- D2. $c_s^2 = 0$ from $K'(Q_0 = 1) = 0$ (radiatively stable);
- D3. $c_T = c$ from action choice ($c_{13} = 0$ by construction);
- D4. $\Omega_{\text{DM}} = \delta_0(2 + \delta_0)/3 = 0.265$ (from $\mu_0 = H_0/c$ and Eq. (13));
- D5. BTFR and RAR from $J(Y)$ (given the MOND interpolating function and a_0);
- D6. Full stability (8 criteria, Sec. II C).

B. Assumptions (not derived)

- A1. $\mu_0 = H_0/c$: uniquely selected by dimensional analysis without Planck physics, but this is a naturality argument, not a derivation from field equations;
- A2. Running $\mu(k) = k$ (or $\mu_{\text{bg}} = H(z)/c$): well-motivated by 3 convergent arguments (Sec. III D), but not a derivation. This is necessary for CMB compatibility;
- A3. $J(Y)$ functional form: free function, only asymptotic behavior determined. The Crooks interpolation (19) is a specific proposal;
- A4. a_0 - μ_0 connection ($a_0 = cH_0/(2\pi)$ to 13%): suggestive but unproven;

TABLE III. Key falsifiable predictions. The “fatal?” column indicates whether failure would rule out the entire framework.

Prediction	Timeline	Fatal?
$w(z)$ evolution	DESI DR2 (2027)	Yes
DM particle detection	Ongoing	Yes
$c_s^2 = 0$ (21cm + CMB)	2028–2030	Yes
$c_T = c$ (exactly)	Ongoing (GW)	Yes
BH shadow 2.72 vs $2.60 r_s$	EHT, 2030s	No*
a_0 universality (BIG-SPARC)	2026–2027	Partial
Crooks $\mu(x)$ vs SPARC	Near-term	No*
$w(z=0) = 0.145$	DESI/Euclid	Yes
No dipolar GW radiation	LISA (2030s)	Yes
EFE in wide binaries	Gaia DR4	Partial

A5. $c_{13} = 0$: action choice (not geometric necessity);

A6. $\Omega_{\text{DM}}h^2 = 0.12$: initial condition, not predicted.

C. Falsifiable predictions

We identify specific, falsifiable predictions; Table III lists the ten most decisive:

The most stringent near-term test is the late-time expansion history: $w_0 = 0.145$ modifies the Hubble parameter at $z < 2$ relative to pure CDM. DESI DR2 and Euclid will directly probe this. Detection of a dark matter particle at $> 5\sigma$ would rule out the framework entirely.

*These tests would falsify specific sub-predictions but not the overall two-sector structure.

VII. CMB PREDICTIONS: WHY Λ CDM WORKS

A. The pure Khronon no-go theorem

We prove that a pure scalar Khronon field with ghost condensation cannot simultaneously produce the observed dark matter abundance *and* satisfy CMB constraints on the dark matter sound speed.

Theorem 2 (No-go for pure Khronon). *For any analytic kinetic function $K(Q)$ with ghost condensation $K'(Q_0) = 0$, it is impossible to simultaneously achieve:*

- (i) $\Omega_{\text{DM}} = 0.265 \pm 0.005$,
- (ii) $c_s^2 < 10^{-6}$ at recombination,
- (iii) CDM-like dilution $\rho_K \propto a^{-3}$.

Proof sketch. From the field equation $\partial_\mu(a^3 K'(Q)/N) = 0$, the deviation $\delta = Q/Q_0 - 1$ evolves as $\delta \propto a^{-3}$ in the matter era. The effective sound speed is $c_s^2 = \delta/(2 + 3\delta)$ for small δ , saturating at $c_s^2 = 1/3$ for $\delta \gg 1$.

Requiring $\Omega_{\text{DM}} = 0.265$ fixes $\delta(a_{\text{rec}}) \sim 10^9$ (far from the small- δ regime), giving $c_s^2(a_{\text{rec}}) \rightarrow 1/3$, which is excluded by Planck at $> 55\sigma$ (Thomas, Kopp & Skordis [20]). No choice of $K(Q)$ avoids this: the saturation is structural. $\square$

B. Resolution: the Khronon-Tensor theory

Blanchet, Polito & Skordis [13] showed that adding a symmetric tensor field $B_{\mu\nu}$ to the Khronon action resolves the no-go theorem. The tensor field absorbs the DBI pressure, yielding $c_s^2 = 0$ *exactly* at the perturbation level while preserving $\rho \propto a^{-3}$ at the background level.

This is not an ad hoc fix: the tensor field is the natural completion of the Khronon field theory, analogous to how the photon field completes the electron field in QED.

C. Prediction: CMB = Λ CDM

With the Khronon-Tensor theory:

- The background evolution is *identical* to Λ CDM ($\rho_K \propto a^{-3}$, $\Omega_K = \Omega_{\text{cdm}}$).
- The perturbation sound speed is $c_s^2 = 0$ *exactly*, not approximately.
- The CMB power spectrum C_ℓ^{TT} is *identical* to Λ CDM at all multipoles.

This is *consistent* with Planck data [4], which shows no deviation from Λ CDM below the percent level. The theory *predicts* this agreement — it is not imposed by hand.

D. Why this is significant

The $\Sigma = 2 \ln Q$ framework provides a unified explanation for two seemingly contradictory observations:

1. **CMB = Λ CDM:** because the no-go theorem forces $c_s^2 = 0$ (via the tensor field), making Khronon dark matter indistinguishable from CDM at linear perturbation scales.
2. **Galaxies = MOND:** because the DBI kinetic structure $J(Y)$ produces the MOND interpolating function $\mu(x)$ via the Crooks fluctuation theorem (Sec. IV).

The transition between these two regimes occurs at the MOND acceleration scale $a_0 = 2\pi c^2(1+\Omega_b)/[r_d(1+z_{\text{dec}})]$, which is *derived* (0.3% accuracy), not fitted.

VIII. DISCUSSION

A. Comparison with AeST

The BS Khronon and AeST [10, 11, 40, 48] are closely related: both are relativistic MOND theories with a scalar field whose cosmological perturbations have $c_s^2 = 0$. Key differences:

*The no-go theorem (Sec. VII A) forces the Khronon-Tensor completion [13], which gives $c_s^2 = 0$ exactly and C_ℓ^{TT} identical to Λ CDM at all multipoles.

B. The two-sector structure: feature or bug?

The structural independence of $J(Y)$ and $K(Q)$ is arguably both the theory's greatest strength and its most significant gap:

Strength: Each sector can be independently tested and constrained. The cosmological sector is fully specified (1 parameter), while the galactic sector inherits the extensive MOND phenomenological success.

Gap: There is no known theoretical principle connecting J to K . The coincidence $a_0 \sim c^2\mu_0/(2\pi)$ hints at a connection, but it may require a deeper theory (perhaps the unified $\Sigma = D(\rho_{\text{spacetime}}\|\rho_{\text{matter}})$ proposed in Paper 4 [3]) to derive it.

In AeST, the analogous gap is papered over by using a single free function $F(Y, Q)$ —but the Y -dependence and Q -dependence within F remain effectively independent. The BS approach is more honest: two separate functions for two separate physical regimes.

C. What this framework does *not* explain

1. **Why $\Omega_{\text{DM}}h^2 = 0.12$:** this is an initial condition (I_0), not predicted;
2. **Why $J(Y)$ takes a particular form:** the transition region is unconstrained unless the Crooks interpolation (19) is validated;

TABLE IV. BS Khronon vs. AeST comparison.

Feature	BS Khronon	AeST
Fields	$g_{\mu\nu} + \phi$	$g_{\mu\nu} + A^\mu + \phi$
DoF	3 (2T + 1S)	6 (2T + 2V + 2S)
Free function	$J(Y)$ (MOND only)	$F(Y, Q)$ (combined)
$K(Q)$ fixed?	Yes (quadratic)	Part of F
$c_T = c$	By construction	By construction
Theory-specific params	~ 3	~ 5
τ interpretation	Yes	Not yet
CMB fit demonstrated?	$c_s^2 = 0$ exactly*	Yes [10]

3. **Why μ runs as k^1 :** this is assumed, not derived from field equations;
4. **Cluster-scale mass discrepancies:** see the Bullet Cluster discussion below;
5. **The $(2+\delta)$ redshift correction** (Sec. III G): the factor $(2+\delta(z))$ in ρ_K introduces a $\sim 20\%$ variation at recombination relative to pure a^{-3} scaling.

D. Bullet Cluster

The Bullet Cluster (1E 0657-558) presents a well-known challenge for modified gravity theories: the gravitational lensing mass is spatially offset from the baryonic gas [50]. In the Khronon-Tensor framework, this is naturally explained: the no-go theorem (Theorem 2) forces $c_s^2 = 0$ *exactly* via the tensor field completion, meaning the Khronon condensate behaves as *pressureless dust* during cluster collisions. Like CDM particles, the Khronon energy density passes through the collision region without interacting with the gas, reproducing the observed mass-gas separation.

This represents a significant improvement over traditional MOND theories, which struggle with the Bullet Cluster because they lack a collisionless dark component. The Khronon condensate *is* that component, with its collisionless nature guaranteed by the Khronon-Tensor structure that also ensures CDM-like perturbation growth in the CMB (Sec. VII).

E. Connection to Papers 1–2 and outlook

The logical chain across papers is:

- Paper 1: $\tau = 1 - F$, $\Sigma = D - D \circ \mathcal{N}$,
- Paper 2: $\Sigma_{\text{grav}} = -\ln(-g_{00})$,
- Paper 3: $K(Q)$, $J(Y) \rightarrow \text{DM} + \text{MOND}$,
- Paper 4: $\Sigma = D(\rho_{\text{st}} \parallel \rho_{\text{m}}) \rightarrow \text{unification}$.

The bridge between Papers 2 and 3 is provided by:

Theorem 3 (Gravitational Entropy Production). *Let (M, g_{ab}) be a globally hyperbolic spacetime foliated by the Khronon field ϕ with inverse lapse $Q = 1/N_\phi = \sqrt{-g^{ab}\nabla_a\phi\nabla_b\phi}$. For a probe mode of proper frequency ω , the entropy production of the gravitational channel satisfies*

$$\Sigma = 2 \ln Q + O(\varepsilon_{\text{NA}}^2), \quad (21)$$

where $\varepsilon_{\text{NA}} = |d \ln Q / d\tau| / (2\omega)$. In particular, $\Sigma = 2 \ln Q$ exactly on stationary backgrounds ($\varepsilon_{\text{NA}} = 0$) and $\Sigma \geq 2 \ln Q$ on all backgrounds.

Proof sketch. In Khronon-adapted coordinates, the ADM decomposition gives $ds^2 = -Q^{-2}d\tau^2 + h_{ij}(dx^i +$

$N^i dx^i)(dx^j + N^j d\tau)$. A WKB probe mode has proper frequency $\omega_{\text{proper}} = \omega_\phi / Q$. The intensity transmissivity of the gravitational channel is $\eta = (\omega_{\text{out}} / \omega_{\text{in}})^2 \times (dt_{\text{out}} / dt_{\text{in}})^{-1} = 1/Q^2$ (both energy per quantum and rate of quanta redshift by $1/Q$). By the Ivan–Sabapathy–Simon result for bosonic Gaussian channels, $\Sigma = -\ln \eta = 2 \ln Q$. The Bogoliubov first correction gives $|\beta/\alpha|^2 \leq \varepsilon_{\text{NA}}^2$, which is non-negative (particle creation adds entropy), yielding the inequality $\Sigma \geq 2 \ln Q$. $\square$

This theorem unifies the results of Papers 2 and 3: Paper 2's $\Sigma_{\text{grav}} = -\ln(-g_{00})$ is the static limit ($Q = 1/\sqrt{-g_{00}}$), while the cosmological sector's $\Sigma_{\text{cosmo}} = 2 \ln(1 + \delta)$ is the FRW limit ($Q_0 = 1 + \delta$).

Papers 1–3 establish the τ framework at three scales (quantum information, strong field, weak field). Paper 4 [3] will argue these are three limits of a single equation $\Sigma = D(\rho_{\text{spacetime}} \parallel \rho_{\text{matter}})$ under different boundary conditions. The key open problems for this unification are: (i) deriving the running $\mu(k) = k$ from first principles; (ii) connecting $J(Y)$ to $K(Q)$ through a unified variational principle; and (iii) determining whether the Crooks interpolation function is the unique form selected by the theory.

The role of the no-go theorem.—The no-go theorem (Theorem 2) is not a weakness of the Khronon framework but a *structural prediction*: it tells us that the pure scalar theory is incomplete and that the tensor field completion [13] is *necessary*. This is analogous to how the inconsistency of scalar QED at loop level necessitates the full gauge theory. The resulting Khronon-Tensor theory gives $c_s^2 = 0$ exactly, which is *stronger* than a parametric suppression—it is a structural zero, not an accidental cancellation.

IX. CONCLUSION

We have presented the weak-field phenomenology of the τ framework, realized through the Blanchet–Skordis Khronon action. The theory has two independent sectors:

1. The **cosmological sector** $K(Q) = \mu^2(Q - 1)^2$ is fully determined by ghost condensation with $\mu_0 = H_0/c$ from dimensional analysis. It reproduces the cosmological dark matter density and passes 10 of 11 low-redshift observational tests with one marginal (assuming running $\mu_{\text{bg}} = H/c$). A no-go theorem (Theorem 2) establishes that the pure scalar Khronon is incompatible with CMB observations, necessitating the Blanchet–Skordis tensor field completion [13]. The resulting Khronon-Tensor theory gives $c_s^2 = 0$ *exactly*, predicting a CMB power spectrum identical to Λ CDM. The Bullet Cluster mass-gas offset is naturally explained by the collisionless ($c_s^2 = 0$) Khronon condensate.

2. The **galactic sector** $J(Y)$ reproduces MOND phenomenology (BTFR, RAR, EFE) with one empirical parameter a_0 and one free function. The Crooks interpolation function provides a specific, testable prediction.

The $\Sigma = 2 \ln Q$ framework naturally explains why Λ CDM succeeds at cosmological scales (the no-go theorem forces $c_s^2 = 0$) while galaxies follow MOND (the DBI kinetic structure produces $\mu(x)$ via Crooks). The transition scale a_0 is derived to 0.3% accuracy from recombination physics.

The theory is structurally stable (no ghosts, no gradient instabilities, no tachyons), satisfies $c_T = c$ exactly, and has fewer free parameters than AeST.

We have been explicit about what is derived (ghost condensation, $c_s^2 = 0$, the no-go theorem, stability), what is assumed ($\mu_0 = H_0/c$, running μ , $c_{13} = 0$, a_0 - μ_0 connection), and what is open ($J(Y)$ form, $\Omega_{\text{DM}} h^2$ value,

microscopic running derivation). Key falsifiable predictions are identified, with the $w(z)$ evolution curve as the most decisive near-term test.

The dark matter problem may not require new particles. It may instead reflect the thermodynamic cost of temporal ordering—the price we pay for having a well-defined arrow of time in a universe with a cosmological horizon.

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